God can therefore be imagined in myriad ways, and in all conceivable shapes and forms, since there is nowhere that God is not, and nowhere that God cannot be. The highest form of God is the Brahman, the Absolute, the universal soul that suffuses all creation.

As a verse in the *Maitreya Upanishad* puts it:

> In the beginning everything was Brahman. He was one, and infinite; infinite in the East, infinite in the South, infinite in the West, infinite in the North, above and below and everywhere infinite. East and the other regions do not exist for him, nor across, nor below, nor above. The Highest Self is not to be fixed, he is unlimited, unborn, not to be reasoned about, not to be conceived. He is like the ether (everywhere), and at the destruction of the universe, he alone is awake. Then from that ether he wakes all this world, which consists of thought only, and by him alone is all this meditated on, and in him it is dissolved. His is that luminous form which shines in the sun, and the manifold light in the smokeless fire, and the fire in the stomach which consumes the food. Thus it is said:
>
> 'He who is in the fire, and he who is in the heart, and he who is in the sun, they are one and the same.' [11]

One of the most famous dialogues in Hindu philosophy, from the *Chandogya Upanishad*, relates to a discussion between a *rishi* (sage) and his son about the existence of God. The young man, Svetaketu, asks his father, Uddalaka Aruni, how he can demonstrate that God exists when there is no visible proof of God's existence. In the typical Hindu manner of instruction, Uddalaka asks his son to fetch a fruit from the banyan tree and cut it open. Inside the fruit, the son finds a small seed. The father asks him to break it apart and see what there is in it, but the seed is all there is. Uddalaka tells his son that all he can see is a small seed; yet something exists in that seed that is so powerful that an immense banyan tree can grow out of it. Similarly, God is not visible, but exists, and the world has grown out of God.

The son is only partly persuaded, so the father asks him to mix salt and water in a bowl. Now, he tells Svetaketu, taste the water and the salt in different parts of the bowl, and once you have done so, separate the salt from the water. The son does as instructed, and points out that the water in every part of the bowl tastes equally salty, and that once dissolved, the salt cannot be separated from the water. Aha, says Uddalaka: you find the salt all-pervasive in the bowl; so too is the universal spirit, which is all-pervasive in creation. When, at the end of